

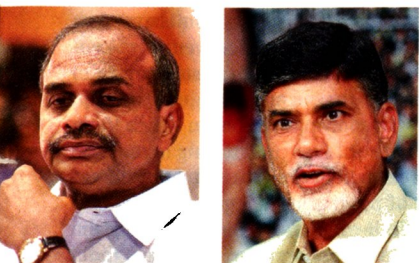


A PRABHAKAR RAO

corruption are the main focus of the PRP chief's attack on his rivals. "They (YSR and Naidu) went to the same school and learnt to practice corruption in virtually the same manner. If one indulged in it a little less than the other, it was because he didn't want to be caught, and if the other maximised corruption, it was because he could not care less," contends Chiranjeevi.

Accusing both YSR and Naidu of conspiring against the PRP to scuttle

PRP'S RIVALS REDDY AND NAIDU (RIGHT)



the prospects of having a chief minister from among the backward classes in the state, he promises cataclysmic changes through social justice and equal opportunity and appeals to people to give him a chance. He is playing the caste card to his advantage which makes his drive different from that of his rivals, though it is well-known that the Congress has a strong Reddy base while TDP has the Kammas on its side.

The arithmetic may work to his advantage but not the chemistry. First, he has not been able to draw influential opinion makers and other local leaders from these groups to his party. Some like Mudragada Padmanabham, a Kapu, are contesting on Congress tickets. Others like former Union coal minister Dasari Narayana Rao, actor and filmmaker, made a spoof called *Mestri* that takes potshots at Chiranjeevi and the PRP. "He cannot rise high enough to be a democratic

leader," says Rao. Political commentator C. Narasimha Rao dismisses him as "an ignorant novice who makes us laugh with his comical acts on the Andhra political stage" and "is only a draw with urban lumpen elements and rural frenzied fans".

Second, Chiranjeevi has not been able to build an enduring organisational network across the state. In the absence of a well-oiled machinery, the PRP is hamstrung in electoral preparedness on several counts. The foremost of these is the legal tangle and delay in finding a common election symbol. Chiranjeevi, who plumped for a steam engine, could not get it for the PRP as it is still not acknowledged as a registered party with the Election Commission. So, he turned to P. Shivshankar, a veteran lawyer-turned-Indira Gandhi acolyte in his heyday and also an ex-governor of Sikkim, to persuade Sikkim Democratic Front leader Pawan Kumar Chamling to share his party symbol, the umbrella, with the PRP. This is after Shivshankar, a backward class leader in his own right, cautioned that a common poll symbol will serve as a deterrent against defection in post-poll horse-trading, both in the Lok Sabha and the Assembly.

Whatever be the chinks in his armour, Chiranjeevi has compensated for it with his cinematic glamour and an equally enduring off-screen act—a humanist image sustained by his pioneering contribution to voluntarism in blood donation by instituting a well-managed blood bank as well as pledging and gifting corneas to enable the blind to see. Clearly, his goodwill is the envy of any political debutant, even more so a wannabe chief minister. But translating goodwill and cinematic charisma-inspired popularity into votes calls for a sterner stuff. Like the hopes he raises among supporters, Chiranjeevi too is confident that his writ runs wide. If his overtures click well, it will be a miracle. If they don't, the PRP will be just another bittersweet experience like the *ugadi pachadi* (a raw mango concoction consumed on the Telugu New Year) for the Congress and the TDP. ■